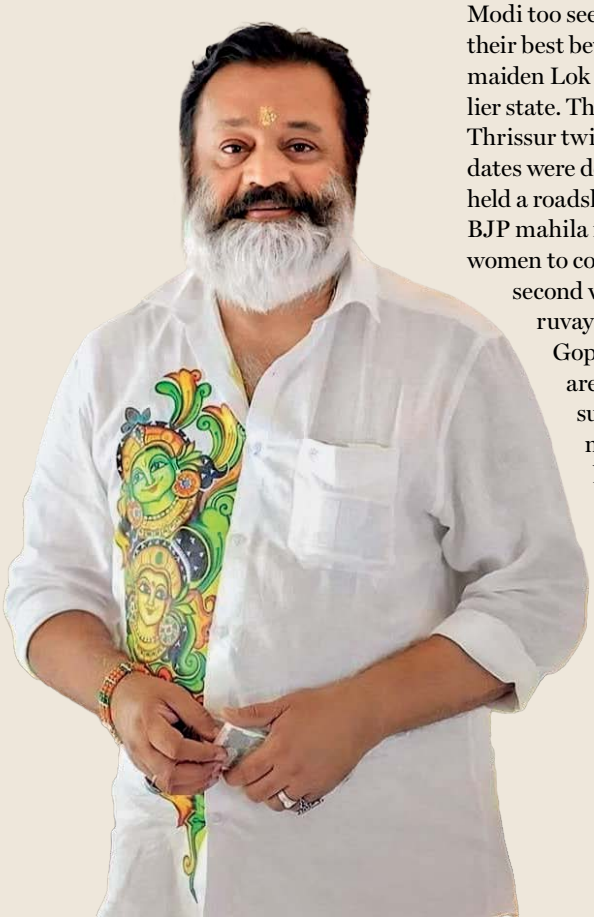
MOLLYWOOD GOES TO THE POLLS

Film stars are shining bright in Kerala's political firmament. The BJP is relying on one to make its LS wish come true

By Jeemon Jacob

Unlike other states in the south, Kerala has never really taken to screen icons playing political leaders in real life. Mollywood stars have made the occasional foray, but they have mostly been short-lived except for K.B. Ganesh Kumar, presently transport minister in the Pinarayi Vijayan-led Left Front government. Ganesh, 57, has been representing the Pathanapuram assembly constituency in Kollam district in south Kerala since 2001, but then he has some political legacy on his side. The part-time actor cum TV anchor is chairperson of the Kerala Congress (Balakrishna Pillai) faction, named after his late father, a revered leader in the region.

Among the few successful sojourns has been the one by yesteryear hero Mukesh who won the Kollam assembly seat in the south in 2016 and 2021. Now the actor has been fielded by the Marxists in the Kollam Lok Sabha seat against sitting MP and Revolutionary Socialist Party (RSP) candidate N.K. Premachandran, and the BJP candidate, small screen actor Krishna Kumar. The latter is also the father of a popular Gen Z actor, Ahaana Krishna, so the locals are quite kicked about the star brigade descending on the constituency to canvass for votes. Krishna Kumar's chances are slim, but he has been running a high-voltage campaign. "I'm seeking votes for Narendra Modiji and for me. The people want a change," he says, adding that his daughters and friends from the TV world will soon join the campaign.



Four-time MP from Kollam, Premachandran, though, is unimpressed. "I've been with the people of Kollam for a long time. I have seen them through their sorrows and their happiness," says the 63-year-old who won with record margins in 2014 and 2019.

The main event, though, is happening in Thrissur in central Kerala where ageing superstar Suresh Gopi is in the ring for the BJP. The 65-year-old was their candidate here in 2019 as well, and though he came in third, he polled 293,882 votes, which was unprecedented for the saffron party. This time, he is up against the Congress's K. Muraleedharan, son of the late chief minister and party veteran K. Karunakaran, and popular Communist Party of India (CPI) leader and ex-agriculture minister V.S. Sunilkumar.

"This time, I will win Thrissur. Look at the crowds at our election meetings. The trend is in favour of the BJP," says an animated Gopi. The party and Prime Minister Narendra Modi too seem to think that Gopi is their best bet for scoring the party's maiden Lok Sabha victory in the outlier state. The PM had already visited Thrissur twice in 2024 before the poll dates were declared. On January 3, he held a roadshow in the city where the BJP mahila morcha got thousands of women to come out for his speech; the second was when he flew in to Guruvayur to attend the nuptials of Gopi's daughter. Party circles are eagerly promoting the superstar as the next Union minister from the state if he gets elected.

Gopi made his name playing high-voltage heroes, mostly the rebel cop fighting the system and mouthing "mass-y dialogues". That may

SURESH GOPI, BJP